> region called *Malai-nadu*, ‘the Hill Country’ … The affix *bar* appears attached to it first in the *Geography* of Edrisi (c. 1150) … Arabic *barr*, ‘a continent’.
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> Col. Henry Yule and A. C. Burnell, *HOBSON-JOBSON, A glossary of colloquial Anglo-Indian words and phrases, 1886*

Cherthala is a fast-expanding township halfway along the long strip of land that runs northwards along the Malabar coast from Alleppey (Alappuzha) to Cochin (Kochi) to form a low-lying barrier between the sea and the lakes and waterways that form part of Kerala’s famous backwaters. In Cherthala’s northern outskirts is a nondescript crossroads now called Manorama Kovala. This was formerly known as Mulachi parambu, although today few people in the locality seem to have heard of it. The Malayalam word *parambu* means ‘plot of land’ and *mulachi* means ‘breasted woman’, so it means something like ‘the home of the breasted woman’.

The Malabar coast has its share of horror stories but few are as arresting as the tale of the housewife of Cherthala who presented her cut-off breasts on a banana leaf to the tax-collector at her door. It is hard to dismiss this particular story as sensational myth because of the details: the tax man running away in shock, the woman bleeding to death from her wounds, and her distressed husband – almost uniquely in Indian history – throwing himself on to her funeral pyre. We know her name, her caste and the place where this happened, but not the exact date. However, this did not happen in the ancient mists of time but in the kingdom of Travancore just over two centuries ago. And even though this was a case of self-harm there was an aggressor involved – in the form of the local Brahmin community and the powers it then exercised.